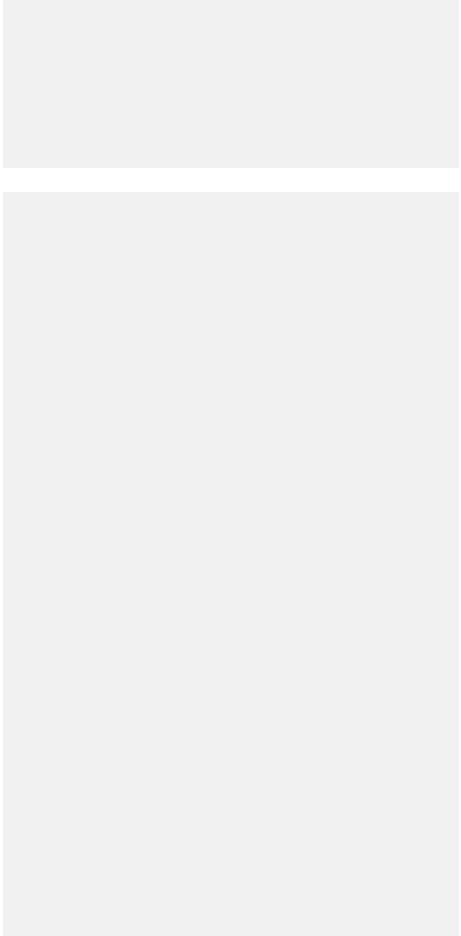




Ownership

Partnerships: An Effective Way of Planning, Developing, Managing, & Maintaining the Ohio River Trail

The Ohio River Trail will be a great asset and wonderful addition to the region. It offers important recreational, health, tourism, and economic benefits to local and regional residents. The trail will help to stimulate the development of new businesses as well as tourism-related opportunities like river rafting or canoe tours, bicycle sales and rentals, restaurants and lodging. It will become a highly desirable recreation destination, which will help to attract and retain businesses, residents (including young families) to the region.

Trail Host Communities

The entire Ohio River Trail, including the North and South shores, will traverse twenty-six (26) western Pennsylvania Communities. While this project focuses on the south shore communities, it is important to consider the ultimate trail, as a whole, when considering management, operations and partnerships strategies. By establishing an effective and creative approach to management rooted in collaboration, additional partners and resources can be folded in as the trail is extended. The eight South Shore communities include the Boroughs of Monaca, South Heights, and Coraopolis, the City of Aliquippa, and the Townships of Center, Hopewell, Crescent, and Moon. The eleven North Shore communities include the

Boroughs of Glasgow, Ohioville, Midland, Industry, Beaver, Bridgewater, Fallston, New Brighton, Rochester, and the Townships of Vanport and Rochester. In addition, the North Shore Extension Communities include the Boroughs of Ambridge, Leetsdale, Edgeworth and Sewickley. The Bradys Run Extension adds Patterson and Brighton Townships.

The eight communities within the South Shore Feasibility study area span two counties, Beaver and Allegheny, and have a combined population of over 75,000 and range in population size from 542 to 22,290 residents. The level of municipal staffing, budget and capacity for maintenance and operations vary widely by jurisdiction. By working together in developing, operating and maintaining the Ohio River Trail, the municipalities will be able to develop and operate the trail as a premiere recreation facility that will be an important asset of the region.

Value of Intergovernmental Collaboration

Intergovernmental collaboration in planning, developing, and maintaining the Ohio River Trail has a sound basis in the following six areas:

- **Interdependence** – *The Ohio River Trail encompasses eight municipalities in two counties and is without jurisdictional borders. By working together, a municipal collaboration can assure that the trail will appear seamless and unified along its entire length. Decisions made by one municipality along the trail will affect other municipalities and the segment of the trail in their respective community.*
- **Effectiveness** - *Public services can be more effective when municipalities work together. This is especially true when facilities, such as the Ohio River Trail, cross boundaries and when special skills or services may be needed for a facility.*
- **Economy of Scale** – *Working together is a smart way of conducting the public’s business in terms of efficient and effective practices that result in cost savings, more “bang for the buck”, and reduction in duplication of services, equipment and spending.*
- **Improved chance for grant funding** – *The trend is for funding agencies, including the Commonwealth of Pennsylvania, to award grants for projects with a regional, multi-municipal, and public private partnership foundations in place.*
- **Higher quality of facilities and services** – *By joining forces, the municipalities can maintain, advertise, program and respond to citizen needs regarding the trail in a higher quality manner than they could independently.*
- **Better, more convenient public service** – *Having a unified trail organization in place enables “one stop shopping” for citizens. The single organization offers a single point of contact that is easily identifiable by the public as the “go to” place for information about the trail, resolution of problems and reporting of issues.*

Ohio River Trail Council: Umbrella Organization

The Ohio River Trail Council (ORTC) is a non-profit volunteer-led corporation that works to bring individuals, communities, businesses, recreational users and all levels of government together to promote and protect a continuous corridor of natural and cultural resources along the Ohio River and its tributaries. The ORTC’s goal is to honor the region’s past and build the future by providing recreation opportunities, heritage development, environmental stewardship, safe transportation

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networks and economic stimulus to the community. The ORTC is an organization committed to excellence, with a clear vision and a passion for delivering outstanding results. The ORTC mission includes the construction of land and water trails through the reallocation of abandoned rail corridors, bridges, trolley lines, brownfields, and canal towpaths. The ORTC encourages additional access to these resources and ensures that these natural areas are afforded protection. The ORTC endorses the revitalization of the natural beauty of the Ohio River and its surroundings, one of Western Pennsylvania’s most important natural resources. The ORTC’s goal is to conserve one of the most diverse ecological ecosystems in Pennsylvania.

The ORTC focuses its efforts on showcasing recreational, educational, historical and cultural sites along the trail. The ORTC is committed to saving and exhibiting collections of historical significance of the region. This preservation provides an enduring record of the past, celebrating our heritage and providing an experience to discover our history with the establishment of the Ohio River Trail Museum.

ORTC as Vehicle for Multi-Municipal Collaboration

The ORTC could serve as the vehicle for a multi-municipal agreement for the Ohio River Trail. Already in place with a positive public image, the ORTC could help to carry out the inter-municipal agreement for the trail development and operation. The ORTC already provides a management foundation to the municipalities in the trail corridor in terms of getting it up and running.

The ORTC could serve in a leadership role in all facets of trail planning, development and operation in the corridor, thereby providing expertise and support that the municipalities have on their own. To that end, the following guiding principles could be established to provide a common and clear foundation for the multi-municipal partnership.

Guiding Principles

- **Productive Partnerships** – *Partners in the inter-municipal agreement would include Beaver and Allegheny Counties, the nine South Shore communities including the boroughs of Monaca, South Heights, Coraopolis and Montour Junction/Groveton, the City of Aliquippa, and the townships of Center, Hopewell, Crescent, and Moon. ORTC would serve as the umbrella organization. Other partners would include CJ Betters Corporation, American Bridge Corporation and the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers. The other 17 municipalities could join the agreement over time as the trail is developed.*
- **Excellent Service** – *Provide the best possible service in the planning and development of the Ohio River Trail that foster high quality experiences for the people who use it.*
- **Trail Planning Leadership** – *Set the standard for trail planning and development in the trail corridor.*
- **Capacity Building** – *Work with the municipalities and other organizations interested in the trail and other trail segments connecting to the Ohio River Trail for the purpose of advancing the trail network in the region.*

- **Wise Decisions** – Base decisions on a solid foundation of information that includes public opinion, environmental, engineering, safety, aesthetics, heritage, transportation and recreation considerations.
- **Effective and Efficient Management** –Develop and implement sound management practices that are action oriented, have accountability, and foster creative and collaborative solutions.
- **Stable Funding** – Strive to provide a stable funding base to support the ORT mission. The projected annual cost for maintaining the ORT covered by this plan is projected to cost about \$25,000 equating to about \$1,500 per mile. On-road lengths will require less maintenance and therefore cost less than off-road segments. Maintenance costs by trail segment will be provided as part of this plan so that each municipality will have the projection for their respective jurisdiction. Other costs for advertising, volunteer management, programs and events would fall to the ORTC.

Other Partnership Opportunities

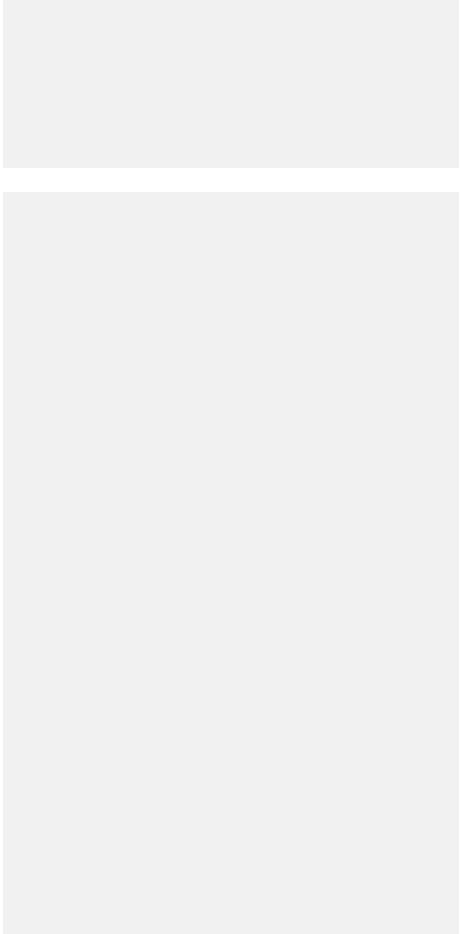
The ORTC is currently pursuing other partnership opportunities to expand the recognition and destination potential of the Ohio River Trail. A few of the partnerships being discussed include with the Adventure Cycling Association to include the ORT as part of the U.S. Bicycling Route 50. The ORTC is also working with the Center for Minority Health at the University of Pittsburgh to include the route as part of the Underground Railroad Pittsburgh Spur. As the trail project advances, opportunities to tie trail development efforts with other overlapping or mutual interested parties will help to elevate the importance of the Ohio River Trail as a local, regional and national asset.

Legislation Authorizing Intergovernmental Cooperation

The Commonwealth of Pennsylvania law authorizing intergovernmental cooperation, now codified in Title 53 of the Pennsylvania Consolidated Statutes, Sections 2301-2315, was originally adopted as Act 180 of 1972. Title 53 authorizes two or more “local governments” to “jointly cooperate in the exercise or in the performance of their respective governmental functions, powers or responsibilities.” Such cooperation is to be authorized by ordinance, which must specify the conditions, duration, purpose, manner, and extent of any financing, organizational structure, manner in which property will be acquired, managed, and disposed of, and that the entity created will be empowered to enter into certain employee related contracts.

Appendix A - Sample Intergovernmental Agreement

A sample agreement for the ORSST communities is provided in Appendix A of this document and is intended to be used as a model to further partnership discussions. This is presented as an example and as the basis for discussion in advancing the intergovernmental agreement for the trail. The process for negotiating this agreement should be determined. This could be done with appropriate existing parties involved with this project such as the ORTC. If no suitable party is in place to undertake this negotiation, the municipalities could consider applying for a Peer Study funded by PADCNr. The Peer Study would be a grant funded project with PADCNr contributing \$10,000 and the partnering communities or another source such as the counties or the ORTC paying a total cost of only \$1,000 as the match. A solicitor must review the agreement with each municipality having their own solicitor review the agreement at appropriate points in development.



Operation and Maintenance

Maintenance is a key facet of all trail management programs. Effective maintenance provides trail users with a clean, safe and enjoyable trail experience while protecting trail ownership from unwanted liability claims. Proper maintenance is also a means to keep the cost of managing the trail in check over the long-term.

General Inspections

General trail inspections provide management with an overall sense of the condition of the trail and allow for planning of upcoming maintenance needs and projects. Trail inspections can occur regularly throughout the year but a spring trail inspection is of particular importance because of the potential problems created by 3-4 months of winter weather. Trail ambassador and friends of the trail groups are a particularly valuable inspection resource because of their frequency of use on the trail. These groups can be advised of what to look for and a reporting system established to relay problems to the appropriate management entity. It is also good practice to keep records of inspections and maintenance activities.

Drainage Inspections

The inspection of drainage facilities which include ditches, swales, culverts and cross pipes, is of particular importance in the overall health of the trail. When functioning properly, they ensure water is directed and handled

accordingly, preventing unwanted erosion of the trail. Inspections facilitate that the drainage system is operating correctly and that impediments can be removed before they cause problems. These should be conducted in the spring and again in the late fall and can be performed by a variety of parties, including volunteers.

Surface Treatment

Treating the surface of the trail is dependent on the type of surface. Crushed stone trails present more maintenance concerns than asphalt trails. Crushed stone trails require some form of grading or dragging on at least an annual basis, sometimes more frequently depending on usage patterns. This can be accomplished with machinery designed for the task or with a drag pulled behind a truck (many regional trail groups have had success in designing “homemade” or machine fabricated drags). Asphalt trail surfaces do not require dragging or grading.

A wooden deck surface, such as that proposed for the boardwalk area between CSX property and the Ohio River also requires specific maintenance. The cost for the care of the surface can be mitigated drastically by using a “trex” or recycled lumber deck. Traditional treated wood decking surfaces require preservative treatment every 2-4 years and the costs of the work and material soon exceed the replacement cost of the wood. The surface of decks should be inspected regularly to ensure that fasteners have not worked themselves loose, which pose potential risks to trail users. This can be easily accomplished by municipal staff or volunteer crews.

Mowing

Mowing, where vegetative shoulders exist along the side the trail, is important to provide for safe, clear recovery zones and also for aesthetic purposes. Mowing shoulders also helps to slow the encroachment of vegetation into the trail surface material, particularly a problem with crushed stone surfaces. In most cases a four to five foot swath is an appropriate mowing width. In heavily used areas, close to access points, wider mowing swaths can be desirable. Mowing can be accomplished through contracted services, municipal cooperation or by the trail group’s volunteer corps. Trail groups also have employed a system of purchasing the equipment and contracting with an operator or coordinating the volunteers. Mowing cycles generally are 1-2 months apart, resulting in mowing requirements of 3-5 times annually. Mowing at parking access areas is an important part of vegetation management. These are often the first areas visitors see and a clean, well-mowed area presents a good first impression. In addition to mowing, hand trimming is also recommended. These areas can be maintained by volunteer labor groups.

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Spraying

Both asphalt and crushed stone trails can require some herbicidal spraying as part of the maintenance program. Spraying helps to prevent parallel vegetation encroachment that, over time, can considerably decrease the width of the trail. It also helps to control vegetation infiltration into the trail surface itself. On crushed stone trails, a spraying/dragging program is particularly effective at managing infiltration. Keep in mind that the application of herbicides should only be conducted by a licensed applicator. Many municipal recreation or public works departments keep someone on staff licensed to spray. Since spraying is usually only required once during the year, late spring preferably, the possibility of cooperatively obtaining this service with other public works entities in the area should be considered.

Tree Trimming

As a maintenance operation, tree trimming helps to maintain vertical clearances and also to catch potential problem limbs and trees before they fall to the ground. Trimming should be conducted initially in the spring to remove tree falls and limb hangers. It is also a good idea to reevaluate the trimming in the late summer or early fall when the trees are vegetated so the effects on vertical clearances can be accurately judged.

Sweeping

Both asphalt and crushed stone surfaces can require sweeping, generally performed in the spring and mid-fall, to remove vegetative debris from the trail. This can be accomplished with machinery designed for this purpose or through cheaper means such as placing individuals on a pickup bed with leaf blowers.

Litter and Graffiti Control

The enforcement of graffiti and litter ordinances will be the responsibility of the relevant municipal police force. Litter control can be accomplished by educating volunteer groups and trail ambassadors to remove litter when they encounter it. Routine monitoring and patrolling by trail users and local support groups will minimize this problem as well.

Law Enforcement/Security

In general, law enforcement will be handled by the local law enforcement agency, with the state police serving as backup. When there is no local agency available, the State Police will provide primary law enforcement services. Several of the communities have or are planning on installing monitoring cameras for portions of their communities. The City of Aliquippa has live cameras along Woodlawn Road, including most of the portions that include the proposed ORSST. Monaca Borough has received funding to locate security cameras along the riverfront, especially targeting the bridge areas.

EMS

When emergencies arise on the trail, the local emergency response networks will generally manage the responses. Access to the local networks is through dialing 911. It is important that coordination with the appropriate EMS providers take place to ensure that access is attainable to areas of the trail system where vehicular use is restricted. It is also important to coordinate with County EMS to develop mapping as trail sections are developed and opened to aid in emergency response. The trail, along with mileposts, should be included in the County GIS inventory used by 911 for emergency dispatching.

Vehicular Use

Although strongly discouraged, there will be times that vehicular use of the trail by others is a necessity. A vehicular use policy should be established that outlines the request process and guidelines for use of the trail. The trail group could request a fee for the privilege.

Signage

A simple standardized signage system should be designed and implemented to deliver clear, concise messaging and promote continuity of the trail system. An effective signage program would include trailblazer signs defining the ORSST trail route as well as connection to neighboring feeder trails. Trail directional signs should provide information related to the location of support services, major destinations and attractions. Mile markers, regulatory signs and interpretive signs for historic and cultural features provide valuable support information to trail users. In addition to its primary purpose, signage can be an important tool in helping to brand the trail. In some cases, the Federal Department of Transportation, Highways Administration, Manual of Uniform Traffic Control Devices (MUTCD) signage will be required which have clear, established guidelines for use and generally are used to alert vehicular traffic of at-grade crossings. Signage should be replaced when damaged or faded.

Friends Group

As the trail is developed, the continued growth and involvement of the Ohio River Trail Council will be an important asset to the long-term care of the trail. The development of an ORTC maintenance committee could spearhead and coordinate the overall care of the trail, where it is likely that a conglomeration of different parties will be participating in the maintenance of the trail. If municipal partners are involved, they should be offered seats on the committee. The ORTC should also develop a volunteer based “trail care crew” whose role would be to provide maintenance assistance and help on special projects matched to skill sets of the members.

Trail Ambassador Program

The ORTC should implement a Trail Ambassador program once sections of trail come on-line. Many of the regional trail groups have established programs that could be copied and modified to meet the needs of the ORTC. Outside of providing a friendly, helpful face to the trail, ambassadors provide an important monitoring function. Often, ambassadors spend as much or more time on the trail than the managing entity and are more in tune with the state of the trail.

The costs associated with maintaining the Ohio River Trail will vary by surface type. The trail system will utilize three different surfaces that each has their own maintenance needs. Of the three types (on-road, 10’ multi-use path, boardwalk) the on-road trail will be the most economical to maintain, followed by boardwalk and then off-road.

Potential Maintenance Costs

The maintenance needs of the on-road route consist of street sweeping done at bi-monthly intervals, pavement marking re-striping/repair, vegetation management and sign replacement as needed. The needs of the boardwalk trail portion consist of the replacement of warped/broken decking and railing, annual superstructure inspections, vegetation management and fastener repair/replacement. The maintenance needs of the off-road asphalt trail include surface repairs, drainage work, vegetation management, mowing, and surface sweeping/clearing. There are inherent costs to trails, regardless of surface type, such as vandalism repair and litter control/trash removal that are built into each cost range shown.

The figures shown represent a range in which maintenance costs will likely fall. The cost of some maintenance activities can be mitigated through volunteer work, donated labor and equipment and preventive measures to lessen future costs. These average ranges, however, do not account for unanticipated costs caused by weather events, natural disasters or other catastrophic failures that otherwise cannot be planned for in annual budget. It is wise to develop a contingency fund or maintenance endowment to help offset the impact of these types of problems.

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Low Cost Range to Maintain Trail by Surface Type per Municipality				
Municipality	On-Road Length	Off-Road Length	Boardwalk Length	Total Length
Monaca Borough	\$ 300.00	\$ 2,100.00		\$ 2,400.00
Center Township	\$ -	\$ 2,250.00		\$ 2,250.00
Hopewell Township	\$ -	\$ 450.00		\$ 450.00
City of Aliquippa	\$ -	\$ 7,350.00		\$ 7,350.00
S. Heights Borough	\$ 30.00	\$ 1,350.00		\$ 1,380.00
Crescent Township	\$ 456.00	\$ 1,140.00		\$ 1,596.00
Moon Township	\$ -	\$ 2,550.00	\$ 560.00	\$ 3,110.00
Coraopolis Borough	\$ 360.00	\$ 870.00		\$ 1,230.00
TOTAL	\$ 1,146.00	\$ 18,060.00	\$ 560.00	\$ 19,766.00

High Cost Range to Maintain Trail by Surface Type per Municipality				
Municipality	On-Road Length	Off-Road Length	Boardwalk Length	Total Length
Monaca Borough	\$ 450.00	\$ 2,800.00		\$ 3,250.00
Center Township		\$ 3,000.00		\$ 3,000.00
Hopewell Township		\$ 600.00		\$ 600.00
City of Aliquippa		\$ 9,800.00		\$ 9,800.00
S. Heights Borough	\$ 45.00	\$ 1,800.00		\$ 1,845.00
Crescent Township	\$ 684.00	\$ 1,520.00		\$ 2,204.00
Moon Township		\$ 3,400.00	\$ 960.00	\$ 4,360.00
Coraopolis Borough	\$ 540.00	\$ 1,160.00		\$ 1,700.00
TOTAL	\$ 1,719.00	\$ 24,080.00	\$ 960.00	\$ 26,759.00

Cost Range to Maintain Per Mile by Surface Type				
	On-Road Length	Off-Road Length	Boardwalk Length	
Low/Mile	\$ 300.00	\$ 1,500.00	\$ 700.00	
High/Mile	\$ 450.00	\$ 2,000.00	\$ 1,200.00	

Cost Range to Maintain Entire Trail System				
	On-Road Length	Off-Road Length	Boardwalk Length	Total Length
Low/17 Miles	\$ 1,146.00	\$ 18,060.00	\$ 560.00	\$ 19,766.00
High/17 Miles	\$ 1,719.00	\$ 24,080.00	\$ 960.00	\$ 26,759.00